ANKYRA

How to Pray

Who you are talking to, how to settle your mind, and how to use the Psalms, the Bible's own prayer book.

Who you are praying to

BEFORE HOW, WHO

Most guidance on prayer starts with technique and skips the question every new Christian actually has: who am I talking to? Christians believe in one God who is three persons. That is not a puzzle to solve before you are allowed to pray; it is the reason prayer works at all.

One God, not three, and not one God wearing three masks. One God who is eternally Father, Son and Spirit. So you are not choosing between them and you cannot pick wrong: all three are involved in every prayer you will ever make.

The pattern Scripture gives

Paul puts the whole thing in a single line: through the Son, and in one Spirit, we have access to the Father. That is the shape of Christian prayer, **to the Father, through the Son, in the Spirit**, whether or not you ever say it out loud.

Ephesians 2:18

1 **The Father: the one you address**

Jesus taught his followers to begin "Our Father", and that is deliberate. Not a force, not a distant authority: a Father, and yours. He hears, and he answers.

Matthew 6:9 · Romans 8:15

2 **The Son: the reason you are allowed in**

Not because you earned it or prayed well, but because Jesus opened the way and still speaks for you. While you are praying, he is at the Father's side putting your case.

Romans 8:34 · Hebrews 4:14–16 · Hebrews 7:25

3 **The Spirit: the one who makes it possible from your side**

He puts the desire to pray in you in the first place, gives you the nerve to call God Father at all, and carries what you cannot put into words. Fully God, and a person: more on him overleaf.

Romans 8:15–16 · Romans 8:26–27 · Ephesians 6:18

Who the Holy Spirit is

WORTH GETTING RIGHT BEFORE YOU PRAY

Of the three persons this is the one most people are vaguest about, and the vagueness shows up in prayer.

1 **A person, not a force**

He can be grieved, he can be lied to, he teaches, and he decides, giving gifts to each one as he wills. None of those are things an influence does. He is a he, not an it.

Ephesians 4:30 · Acts 5:3–4 · 1 Corinthians 12:11

2 **Fully God**

Peter tells Ananias he has lied to the Holy Spirit, then in the next breath says he has lied to God. Same statement. Not a lesser third.

Acts 5:3–4

3 **Sovereign**

He distributes as he determines, not as we request. Jesus compared him to the wind: you hear it without controlling it. Not a resource to be operated.

1 Corinthians 12:11 · John 3:8

4 **Eternally proceeding from the Father and the Son**

Not created, and not brought into being at Pentecost. He proceeds eternally from both, which is why Scripture calls him the Spirit of God and the Spirit of his Son alike.

John 15:26 · Galatians 4:6 · Westminster Confession 2.3

> **One phrase to avoid**
>
> You will hear the Spirit called God's "active force". Do not use it. That is Watchtower language: Jehovah's Witnesses use that exact phrase, and liken him to electricity, precisely to deny that he is a person. Say **person**, not force.

So can I pray to him?

YES, AND HERE IS THE BETTER QUESTION

He is fully God and a person, so there is nothing improper in speaking to him, as the church has done for centuries. But notice what he himself does: Jesus said the Spirit would not speak on his own account, but would take what belongs to the Son and make it known. John 16:13–14 So praying in the Spirit rather than to him is no demotion; it is agreeing with what he is already doing.

> **There is no switchboard**
>
> The common mistake is to divide God into departments: the Father for provision, Jesus for forgiveness, the Spirit for power. Do not. It quietly turns one God into three specialists and leaves you anxious about dialling the right one. Every prayer goes to one God. The three persons are not three offices; they are three ways the one God is at work in the single act of you praying.

Two more questions

ASK THEM OUT LOUD: EVERYBODY HAS THEM

Can I pray to Jesus directly?

Yes, and the New Testament does it without apologising. Stephen, while he was being stoned, asked the Lord Jesus to receive his spirit. Paul pleaded with the Lord three times about the thorn in his flesh. The early church prayed "Come, Lord Jesus." He is fully God. Speaking to him directly is natural and right.

Acts 7:59 · 2 Corinthians 12:8 · Revelation 22:20

What does "in Jesus' name" actually mean?

Not a sign-off and not a password. It means: I am here on his account, not on mine. You can say the words or leave them out. It is equally true either way, and a prayer does not count more for having them tacked on the end.

John 14:13

What prayer actually is

AND FOUR THINGS IT IS NOT

Talking to God, who is already listening. That is the whole of it. When Jesus was asked about it he told people to go into a room, shut the door, and talk to their Father, and warned them specifically against long words and showing off. Matthew 6:5–8

It is not a spell. There are no right words that unlock a result and wrong ones that do not.

It is not a performance. Nobody is marking it. God is not impressed by vocabulary and never has been.

It is not only asking. So is thanking, complaining, confessing, and sitting there saying nothing.

It is not something to be good at first. Nobody is. People who have prayed for forty years still find it hard.

Settling your mind

WHERE TO STAND WHILE YOU TALK

You sit down to pray and your head is full of work, the bills, and something somebody said on Tuesday. Everybody has this. It is a sign of having a life, not a cold heart.

You do not need a blank mind. Emptying your head is hard and is not the goal; a mind with nothing in it drifts back to the bills. You want a settled mind, not an empty one.

Three pictures Scripture gives you

Use whichever fits the day. You are not imagining God into being; you are using images the Bible itself supplies.

1 **The throne**

Isaiah saw the Lord on a throne, high and lifted up, and his first reaction was terror. Put yourself there, kneeling. Then the other half: Hebrews says approach that same throne with confidence, because the one who opened the way stands beside it. Awe and welcome together.

Isaiah 6:1–5 · Revelation 4 · Hebrews 4:16

2 **The father running**

Some days the throne is too much. The son is still a long way off, rehearsing his apology, and the father sees him and runs. Not waits: runs. Same God, same throne.

Luke 15:20

3 **Simply be still**

No picture at all. Sit, say nothing, let your breathing slow, and turn one line over: be still, and know that I am God.

Psalm 46:10

Take your time. There is no clock. The quiet before you say anything is part of the prayer, not the waiting room for it.

IF YOU CANNOT SPEAK AT ALL

Some days there are no words. That is not a failed prayer; it is specifically provided for.

Paul says we do not know what we ought to pray for, and that the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groans that words cannot carry. When you cannot pray, he is already praying for you, and he is not guessing at what you need. Romans 8:26–27

So invite him and stop. “Holy Spirit, I’ve got nothing today. Pray for me.” Then sit there. That is a real prayer: on the worst days, the truest one.

The prayer Jesus gave

A PATTERN, NOT JUST WORDS TO RECITE

Someone asked Jesus how to pray and he answered with six lines. Most people learn them by heart and stop there. They work better as headings: six things to talk to God about, in order, filled in with your own life.

Matthew 6:9–13 · Luke 11:2–4

"Our Father in heaven" Start with who you are talking to. Not a force, not a distant authority: a Father, and yours.

"Hallowed be your name" Before asking for anything, say who he is. It puts the rest in proportion.

"Your kingdom come, your will be done" His agenda before yours. Easily the hardest line in it, and the one most worth meaning.

"Give us today our daily bread" Now ask. Ordinary things, today's worth. He is not above the small stuff.

"Forgive us… as we forgive" Confess what needs confessing. And notice there is a condition attached to that one.

"Lead us not into temptation" Ask for help with what is coming, not only what has happened.

Five minutes on those six headings, with your own week in each, is a complete and serious prayer, and it is the only prayer Jesus is recorded as actually teaching.

When, and for how long

HABIT BEATS INTENTION

- **Attach it to something you already do.** The kettle, the commute, sitting down at your desk, the last five minutes before bed. A prayer with no fixed place in the day is a prayer you will keep meaning to say.
- **Five minutes daily beats an hour on a Sunday.** Frequency does more than length, and always has.
- **Same time each day.** That turns it from a decision into a habit, and it is the decisions that fail, not the habits.
- **If you can only manage one, make it the morning one.** It is easier to pray about a day you have not had yet than to review one that has already gone wrong.
- **Out loud, in the car, counts.** There is no posture requirement and never was.

Three seasons

YOU ARE ALWAYS IN ONE OF THEM, AND SO IS EVERY PSALM

The simplest way to know where to start is to work out which of three places you are in. Every psalm belongs to one of them too. Match the two up and you will never open the book not knowing what to read.

1 **When life is steady**

Work is fine, home is fine, God feels near enough. These psalms are gratitude and settled trust.

Psalms 8, 23, 24, 33, 103, 104, 133, 145

2 **When it falls apart**

Illness, bereavement, redundancy, a marriage in trouble, or the sense that God has gone quiet. These psalms complain, argue and demand, and are not less holy for it.

Psalms 13, 22, 42, 51, 73, 74, 86, 88, 137

3 **When you come out the other side**

Not back where you started: somewhere new, with gratitude that has been through something.

Psalms 30, 40, 47, 98, 116, 126, 148, 150

This grouping comes from Walter Brueggemann's *The Message of the Psalms* (1984): not the only way to sort a hundred and fifty poems, but much the most useful one in practice.

If you feel like this, start here

TWELVE ENTRY POINTS

Grateful	103, 145	**Worn out**	23, 62, 131
Guilty	32, 51	**Alone**	25, 142
Frightened	27, 46, 91	**Doubting**	73, 77
Angry at someone	35, 109	**Rescued**	30, 40, 116
Angry at God	13, 44, 88	**Amazed**	8, 19, 139
Grieving	42, 43, 88	**Nothing in particular**	1, 100, 150

> **About the angry ones**
>
> Some psalms are genuinely shocking. Psalm 137 ends by calling down horrors on Babylon's children; Psalm 109 is a sustained curse. They are in on purpose. Notice what the psalmist does with his rage: he hands it to God rather than dealing with it himself. That is the model, and it beats pretending.

Four steps, about ten minutes

THE SAME FOUR EVERY TIME

Pick a psalm using the three seasons, or work through the Psalms a few at a time. Then do this with it.

1. **Read it slowly, out loud if you can**
   These were written to be spoken and sung, not skimmed.

2. **Find the line that lands**
   There will be one. Some days the first verse, some days one buried in the middle.

3. **Say it back in your own words**
   With your own situation in it. “How long, Lord” becomes “how long is this going on for, because I have had enough.”

4. **Stop there**
   You need not finish the psalm. One verse prayed honestly beats twenty read dutifully.

> **Worked example: Psalm 13, six verses**
>
> **Verses 1–2: the complaint.** How long, Lord? Will you forget me for ever? He asks it four times and does not apologise for asking.
>
> **Verses 3–4: the ask.** Look at me. Answer me. Straight, specific and unembarrassed.
>
> **Verses 5–6: the turn.** But I trust your unfailing love. Nothing outward has changed; he has simply decided where to stand.

Complaint, ask, turn. Nearly every lament in the book runs that way, and once you have seen it you can pray that shape about anything that is wrong in your life this week, in your own words, without needing a psalm open in front of you at all.

> **A reasonable habit**
>
> One psalm a day, in order, gets you through all hundred and fifty in five months. Most of them are short. If you hit one that does nothing for you, move on without guilt: the Psalms were gathered over centuries and were never meant to be read like a novel.

Praying out loud with others

THE BIT NOBODY ADMITS TO DREADING

This is one of the most common fears in any church or small group, and almost nobody says it out loud. So, plainly:

Short is better. Three sentences said plainly beat two minutes of wandering. Nobody has ever complained that a prayer was too short.

Nobody is assessing you. The others are not weighing your vocabulary. Most are quietly relieved it is not their turn.

One sentence is a prayer. “God, thank you for these friends, and help Sam this week. Amen.” That is a complete prayer and it is a good one.

You can pass. “I’ll pray silently today” is a respectable thing to say.

Use normal words. You do not need “Father God we just come before you.” Talk the way you talk. He already knows how you talk.

Pray for the person next to you, by name. The easiest way in, and the thing they will remember on the way home.

Four honest problems

EVERY ONE OF THEM NORMAL

“I don’t know what to say.” Use a psalm, or the Lord’s Prayer. Borrowed words are still your prayer: the church has prayed this way for two thousand years.

“My mind wanders.” Everyone’s does. Pray out loud, walk while you pray, or write it down. A wandering mind is a body with a brain in it, not a spiritual failure.

“I don’t feel anything.” Feeling was never the measure. You were heard on the flat days exactly as much as on the good ones.

“I’ve not prayed for weeks.” Then pray tonight. There is no penance and nothing to catch up on. Walk back in and start talking.

THE THING THE FEAR GETS WRONG

You are not trying to get God’s attention: you already have it. Prayer is not shouting across a gap. It is talking to someone already in the room, who came a long way to be there.

Sources. The three seasons are from Walter Brueggemann, *The Message of the Psalms* (1984). Claus Westermann established lament as the basic form of psalm-prayer. Estimates of how much of the Psalms is lament run from a third to nearly forty per cent depending on who counts.

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